Spain: Right-wing parties on course for a majority

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Spain
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Right-wing parties remain on course for a majority

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Right-wing opposition parties remain on track to win a majority in the 29 November parliamentary elections, likely resulting in a center-right government led by the conservative Popular Party (PP), with the right-wing Vox as the junior partner (an 80% probability, up from 70%).
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The incumbent Socialist Party (PSOE) and its left-wing and regional allies still have a path to victory (20% probability), but persistent fragmentation on the left, the right's durable lead, and the Toledo train crash have narrowed it further.
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Fiscal risks are growing, but a right-wing government would likely continue gradual fiscal adjustment in line with EU requirements, tighten immigration policy, extend the lifespan of nuclear power plants without meaningfully weakening support for renewables, and likely avoid new bank levies.

Right-wing parties are on course for a comfortable majority. A month into the election campaign, the PP and Vox maintain a solid lead. They are polling at about 55% combined, enough to win about 200 out of 350 seats. Their advantage may be overstated, but the ruling center-left alliance is unlikely to close the gap before the vote.

The left's path to retaining a majority is narrowing. In line with Eurasia Group expectations, polls narrowed slightly since early October as the PP lost some ground to Vox and PSOE edged up. The PP's ineffective campaign and the PSOE's early success in leveraging housing discontent to mobilize its base helped drive that shift.

Furthermore, in previous national elections, polling averages tended to overestimate the right (by about seven seats). If repeated, and combined with a sustained drift toward Vox and the PSOE, that pattern could have brought the left within reach of a majority. However, developments over the past two weeks

have made a comeback less likely.

Fragmentation puts the left at a disadvantage. The PSOE would have to enlist as many as nine smaller leftist and/or regional parties to retain a majority. Since the electoral system penalizes small parties, the failure of the PSOE's allies to coalesce into fewer lists significantly benefits the opposition.

The Toledo train accident is a blow for the government. Last week, a major train accident on the Madrid-Seville line killed 69 people. Whatever the cause, apparently a mix of technical failure and human error, the government is unlikely to escape blame. This is the second deadly train crash on the same line this year. Senior PSOE officials, including a former transport minister, are under investigation for serious corruption, including over (unrelated) railway contracts.

With a month remaining before the elections, the crash's effect should not be overstated. Previous shocks, such as the mass border breach in Ceuta in July, had only a limited lasting impact. Still, the accident has shifted the campaign's focus away from housing and back to corruption, safety, and deficient public services. Opinion polls suggest the accident has already blunted the left's momentum, reversing recent gains.

The PSOE's chances hinge on mobilizing the left-wing vote. By calling elections after demonstrations over housing shortages and its failure to pass related decrees, the government hoped to leverage public discontent. Unions have called a general strike for 11 November. The following day, the government will adopt the rejected measures by decree, including new restrictions on rentals and short-term vacation rentals, using a questionable constitutional loophole. Any further gains for Vox could also boost left-wing turnout.

Protests were initially positive for the government but may backfire. Spain's housing protests predate the riots in France and, unlike them, were well organised, mostly non-violent, made clear policy demands, with unions playing a key role. More recently, riots resembling those in France have broken out in several cities, marked by looting and clashes with police by teenagers with no clear political agenda. If sustained, the riots could give right-wing parties another late boost, as could the possible return of exiled Catalan pro-independence leader Carles Puigdemont, whose amnesty has just been processed.

Fiscal risks are rising, but Spain will likely meet EU requirements. Although the government has not passed a budget since 2023, fiscal balances have steadily improved in line with EU requirements, thanks to strong growth, buoyant revenue, and contained spending. However, Spain will face tighter fiscal constraints from 2027, owing to slowing growth and fiscal slippage in 2026, when the government enacted a spate of measures to offset rising fuel prices.

Spain is at risk of breaching EU fiscal targets, which may require some degree of fiscal consolidation in the coming years. Revenue may yet surprise to the upside, but any new government will come under pressure to extend some energy price support measures. Large transfers of EU-funded investment will taper off from 2027. That pressure conflicts with the PP's campaign pledges to cut taxes, including the personal income tax, and to index income tax brackets to inflation. Vox's economic program envisions more drastic, though unrealistic, tax cuts. On balance, Eurasia Group expects an incoming PP-led government to continue a gradual fiscal adjustment and maintain compliance with EU rules, possibly after a partial renegotiation, even if that requires scaling back or deferring some flagship tax pledges. This balancing act would, however, become much harder if growth slows materially. The outlook for structural reforms to help sustain strong economic growth over time is unlikely to improve.

The new government will tighten immigration policy to a degree. Net migration, mainly from Latin America, has been a key driver of strong growth. Changes will mainly involve tightening paths to citizenship and permanent residency and halting future amnesties but will stop short of large-scale repatriations. This approach will gradually weigh on the labor supply rather than cause a near-term crunch.

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